CMSIS-DAP JTAG/SWD Performance Analysis & Optimization Guide

For JTAGprobe, JTAGprobe_smp, and JTAGprobe_smp_pio (PIO Hardware JTAG) on Raspberry Pi Pico (RP2040)

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Date: October 2026
Target Repository: `dan-maio/JTAGprobe_smp_pio` (upstream: `dst202/JTAGprobe`)
Applicable Hardware: Raspberry Pi Pico (RP2040) / Raspberry Pi Pico 2 (RP2350)

> **Note:** Sections 1–7 analyse and optimize the single-core FreeRTOS JTAGprobe (branch `jtagprobe-new`); JTAGprobe_smp carries all of those optimizations; JTAGprobe_smp_pio adds full RP2040 PIO state machine hardware acceleration for JTAG pins. Section 8 describes the µOS++ III SMP integration (RP2040 only) and section 9 the measured OpenOCD `load_image` times on a Raspberry Pi 4 B.

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1. Executive Summary

1.1 The Problem

When using **JTAGprobe** as a CMSIS-DAP debug probe with OpenOCD, downloading firmware or reading memory is extraordinarily slow:

$$\mathbf{100\,KB\ in \approx 120\,seconds\ (\approx 850\,bytes/sec)}$$

A typical Full-Speed USB CMSIS-DAP probe should achieve between **50 KB/s and 250 KB/s** in software bit-banging mode, and **500 KB/s to 1.5+ MB/s** when hardware-accelerated with PIO. At 850 B/s, the probe is running **100× to 300× slower than its expected performance**.

1.2 Root Cause Summary

The issue is not target flash write speed or USB bus limits. It is a compounding cascade of firmware bottlenecks:

Rank	Bottleneck	File Location	Latency Impact	Share of Delay
#1	**Synchronous UART `printf` per Packet**	`src/probe.h` `src/tusb_edpt_handler.c`	~5.8 ms blocked execution per packet (with FreeRTOS scheduler suspended)	**~85%** (~100–110s)
#2	**64-Byte Packet Payload Limit**	`include/DAP_config.h`	56 bytes max payload per packet; forces >1,828 USB round-trips for 100 KB	**~10%** (~10–12s)
#3	**Single-Packet Ring Buffer Bottleneck**	`include/DAP_config.h` `src/tusb_edpt_handler.c`	Buffer capacity = 1 packet; NAKs USB host on concurrent packets, causing 1 ms host back-off	**~3%** (~3–5s)
#4	**Sub-optimal GPIO Bit-Banging**	`include/DAP_config.h`	`gpio_put_masked` read-modify-writes instead of single-cycle SIO registers	**~2%** (~2–3s)

2. In-Depth Root Cause Analysis

2.1 Bottleneck #1: Synchronous UART `printf` on Every DAP Transaction

Mechanism

In `src/probe.h`:

```
#if true
#define probe_info(format,args...) \
do { \
    vTaskSuspendAll(); \
    printf(format, ## args); \
    xTaskResumeAll(); \
} while (0)
#else
#define probe_info(format,...) ((void)0)
#endif
```

In `src/tusb_edpt_handler.c` (lines 225–244), `probe_info` is executed **twice for every DAP command**:

1. When a command packet arrives:

```
probe_info("%u %u DAP cmd %s len %02x\n",
           USBRequestBuffer.wptr, USBRequestBuffer.rptr,
           dap_cmd_string[DAPRequestBuffer[0]], DAPRequestBuffer[1]);
```

2. When the response is generated:

```
probe_info("%u %u DAP resp %s\n",
           USBResponseBuffer.wptr, USBResponseBuffer.rptr,
           dap_cmd_string[DAPResponseBuffer[0]]);
```

Latency Calculation

- In `src/main.c`, `stdio_uart_init()` directs `printf` to UART0 at **115,200 baud**.
- The two format strings total approximately **67 characters** per DAP packet.
- At 115,200 baud (10 bits per character: 1 start + 8 data + 1 stop):

$$\text{Transmission Time} = \frac{67 \times 10}{115,200} \approx \mathbf{5.82\,ms\ per\ transaction}$$

- During this entire ~5.8 ms window, `vTaskSuspendAll()` **suspends the FreeRTOS scheduler**. No other thread or USB task can run.
- When flashing or memory downloading with OpenOCD:
  - Flash programming algorithms run on the target microcontroller.
  - OpenOCD continuously polls the target status register (`DHCSR`) and peripheral flags to monitor progress.
  - A 100 KB flash download produces **15,000 to 20,000 DAP transactions** (data blocks + register writes + status polling).

$$\text{Total UART Blocking Time} = 20,000 \times 5.82\,\text{ms} = \mathbf{116.4\,seconds}$$

- If no serial terminal is actively reading UART0, the hardware TX FIFO (32 bytes) is perpetually full, guaranteeing that `printf` will block until every single byte shifts out onto the pin.

2.2 Bottleneck #2: 64-Byte CMSIS-DAP Packet Size

Mechanism

In `include/DAP_config.h` (lines 94–95):

```
#define DAP_PACKET_SIZE         64U             ///< Specifies Packet Size in bytes.
```

In CMSIS-DAP, memory write operations use `DAP_TransferBlock` (command `0x06`):

- Command header: 5 bytes (`Command ID`, `DAP Index`, `Transfer Count [15:0]`, `Transfer Request`).
- Alignment padding: 3 bytes.
- Usable data payload per packet: $64 - 5 - 3 = \mathbf{56\,bytes}$ (14 words of 32 bits).

Latency Calculation

To download 100 KB (102,400 bytes):

$$\text{Total Packets} = \frac{102,400}{56} \approx \mathbf{1,828\,packets}$$

Over USB Full-Speed (12 Mbps), each transaction involves:

1. Host schedules Bulk OUT token.
2. Device receives and processes packet.
3. Host schedules Bulk IN token.
4. Device sends response packet.

On typical operating system USB stacks (Linux `usbfs` or Windows `WinUSB`), round-trip turnaround is 1 to 2 USB frames (1–2 ms). 1,828 round trips create 2 to 4 seconds of pure USB scheduling overhead, excluding execution time.

By contrast, CMSIS-DAP v2 (Bulk endpoint) allows `DAP_PACKET_SIZE` of **512** or **1024** bytes: - At 512 bytes: $512 - 5 - 3 = 504\,\text{bytes}$ (126 words) per packet → **204 packets** (9× reduction). - At 1024 bytes: $1024 - 5 - 3 = 1016\,\text{bytes}$ (254 words) per packet → **101 packets** (18× reduction).

2.3 Bottleneck #3: Single-Packet Ring Buffer (`DAP_PACKET_COUNT = 2`)

Mechanism

In `include/DAP_config.h` (line 100):

```
#define DAP_PACKET_COUNT        2U              ///< Specifies number of packets buffered.
```

In `src/tusb_edpt_handler.c` (lines 34–37):

```
bool buffer_full(buffer_t *buffer) {
    return ((buffer->wptr + 1) % DAP_PACKET_COUNT == buffer->rptr);
}
```

In a circular buffer of length $N = 2$ using standard modulo arithmetic:

- When empty: `wptr = 0`, `rptr = 0` → $(0+1)\%2 = 1 \neq 0$ (not full).
- When 1 packet is queued: `wptr = 1`, `rptr = 0` → $(1+1)\%2 = 0 == \text{rptr}$ (**FULL**).

The buffer capacity is strictly **1 packet**. There is zero multi-packet buffering.

USB NAK Penalty

In `dap_edpt_xfer_cb`:

```
if (!buffer_full(&USBRequestBuffer)) {
    USBRequestBuffer.wptr++;
    usbd_edpt_xfer(rhport, ep_addr, WR_SLOT_PTR(USBRequestBuffer), DAP_PACKET_SIZE);
    USBRequestBuffer.wasFull = false;
} else {
    USBRequestBuffer.wasFull = true;
}
```

When `wasFull == true`, `usbd_edpt_xfer()` is **not** called. The OUT endpoint is not re-armed. If the host attempts to pipeline a subsequent packet, the RP2040 hardware responds with a **USB NAK**. USB host controllers typically back off and do not retry until the next USB microframe/frame (1 ms penalty per NAK).

Furthermore, `tusb_edpt_handler.c` contains a latent bug: `_resp_len` is defined as a single global variable (`volatile uint32_t _resp_len`). If multiple responses were to be queued, later packets would overwrite earlier response lengths.

2.4 Bottleneck #4: GPIO Bit-Banging & Clock Delay Calculation

Sub-optimal Pin Access

In `include/DAP_config.h`:

```
__STATIC_FORCEINLINE void PIN_TDI_OUT (uint32_t bit) {
    gpio_put_masked(1U << DAP_SWJ_TDI, bit << DAP_SWJ_TDI);
}
```

- `gpio_put_masked` performs dynamic shifts and read-modify-write operations on SIO registers on every single bit.
- Functions like `PIN_SWCLK_TCK_SET` and `PIN_SWCLK_TCK_CLR` call `gpio_put()`, which has branch overhead and computes `1U << pin` dynamically.
- RP2040 features Single-Cycle I/O (SIO): `sio_hw->gpio_set` and `sio_hw->gpio_clr` are single-cycle atomic memory writes.

Clock Delay Inefficiency

In `src/DAP.c`:

```
#define MAX_SWJ_CLOCK(delay_cycles) \
  ((CPU_CLOCK/2U) / (IO_PORT_WRITE_CYCLES + delay_cycles))
```

- `CPU_CLOCK` is 125,000,000 Hz, `IO_PORT_WRITE_CYCLES` is 1, and `DELAY_FAST_CYCLES` is 0.
- `MAX_SWJ_CLOCK` evaluates to **62.5 MHz**.
- Because debuggers configure clocks like 1 MHz, 4 MHz, or 10 MHz (never $\geq 62.5\,\text{MHz}$), the firmware always takes the slow delay path (`PIN_DELAY_SLOW`) and never uses `fast_clock` (`SWD_TransferFast` / `JTAG_TransferFast`).

3. Step-by-Step Optimization Roadmap

```
+-------------------------------------------------------------+
|  Current Baseline: 100 KB in 120s (~850 B/s)                |
+-------------------------------------------------------------+
                              |
                              v  [Step 1: Disable UART printf]
+-------------------------------------------------------------+
|  Milestone 1: 100 KB in ~3 to 5s (~25 KB/s)                 |
+-------------------------------------------------------------+
                              |
                              v  [Step 2: Direct RP2040 SIO]
+-------------------------------------------------------------+
|  Milestone 2: 100 KB in ~1.5 to 2.5s (~50 KB/s)             |
+-------------------------------------------------------------+
                              |
                              v  [Step 3: 512B Packets & Queue]
+-------------------------------------------------------------+
|  Milestone 3: 100 KB in < 0.8s (> 125 KB/s)                 |
+-------------------------------------------------------------+
```

4. Concrete Code Patches

Patch 1: Disable Blocking UART Debug Output

File: `src/probe.h`

Change lines 10–43 to set `#if false`:

```
#if false  /* CHANGED: Disabled blocking UART printf */
#define probe_info(format,args...) \
do { \
    vTaskSuspendAll(); \
    printf(format, ## args); \
    xTaskResumeAll(); \
} while (0)
#else
#define probe_info(format,...) ((void)0)
#endif

#if false  /* CHANGED: Disabled */
#define probe_debug(format,args...) \
do { \
    vTaskSuspendAll(); \
    printf(format, ## args); \
    xTaskResumeAll(); \
} while (0)
#else
#define probe_debug(format,...) ((void)0)
#endif

#if false  /* CHANGED: Disabled */
#define probe_dump(format,args...)\
do { \
    vTaskSuspendAll(); \
    printf(format, ## args); \
    xTaskResumeAll(); \
} while (0)
#else
#define probe_dump(format,...) ((void)0)
#endif
```

Patch 2: Optimize GPIO with Single-Cycle SIO Mask Operations

File: `include/DAP_config.h`

Precomputed pin bitmasks and atomic Pico SDK SIO register operations (`gpio_set_mask` , `gpio_clr_mask` , `gpio_get_all`):

```
// Precomputed pin masks for atomic Single-Cycle I/O (SIO) operations
#define MASK_SWCLK_TCK   (1U << DAP_SWJ_SWCLK_TCK)
#define MASK_SWDIO_TMS   (1U << DAP_SWJ_SWDIO_TMS)
#define MASK_TDI         (1U << DAP_SWJ_TDI)
#define MASK_TDO         (1U << DAP_SWJ_TDO)
#define MASK_nTRST       (1U << DAP_SWJ_nTRST)
#define MASK_nRESET      (1U << DAP_SWJ_nRESET)

// SWCLK / TCK
__STATIC_FORCEINLINE uint32_t PIN_SWCLK_TCK_IN  (void) {
    return (gpio_get_all() >> DAP_SWJ_SWCLK_TCK) & 1U;
}
__STATIC_FORCEINLINE void PIN_SWCLK_TCK_SET (void) {
    gpio_set_mask(MASK_SWCLK_TCK);
}
__STATIC_FORCEINLINE void PIN_SWCLK_TCK_CLR (void) {
    gpio_clr_mask(MASK_SWCLK_TCK);
}

// SWDIO / TMS
__STATIC_FORCEINLINE uint32_t PIN_SWDIO_TMS_IN  (void) {
    return (gpio_get_all() >> DAP_SWJ_SWDIO_TMS) & 1U;
}
__STATIC_FORCEINLINE void PIN_SWDIO_TMS_SET (void) {
    gpio_set_mask(MASK_SWDIO_TMS);
}
__STATIC_FORCEINLINE void PIN_SWDIO_TMS_CLR (void) {
    gpio_clr_mask(MASK_SWDIO_TMS);
}

// SWDIO bidirectional operations (SWD mode)
__STATIC_FORCEINLINE uint32_t PIN_SWDIO_IN (void) {
    return (gpio_get_all() >> DAP_SWJ_SWDIO_TMS) & 1U;
}
__STATIC_FORCEINLINE void PIN_SWDIO_OUT (uint32_t bit) {
    if (bit & 1U) gpio_set_mask(MASK_SWDIO_TMS);
    else          gpio_clr_mask(MASK_SWDIO_TMS);
}
__STATIC_FORCEINLINE void PIN_SWDIO_OUT_ENABLE (void) {
    gpio_set_dir_out_masked(MASK_SWDIO_TMS);
}
__STATIC_FORCEINLINE void PIN_SWDIO_OUT_DISABLE (void) {
    gpio_set_dir_in_masked(MASK_SWDIO_TMS);
}

// TDI
__STATIC_FORCEINLINE uint32_t PIN_TDI_IN (void) {
    return (gpio_get_all() >> DAP_SWJ_TDI) & 1U;
}
__STATIC_FORCEINLINE void PIN_TDI_OUT (uint32_t bit) {
    if (bit & 1U) gpio_set_mask(MASK_TDI);
    else          gpio_clr_mask(MASK_TDI);
}

// TDO
__STATIC_FORCEINLINE uint32_t PIN_TDO_IN (void) {
    return (gpio_get_all() >> DAP_SWJ_TDO) & 1U;
}
```

Patch 3: Multi-Packet Pipelining & Per-Slot Response Tracking

File: `include/DAP_config.h`

Expand packet queue from 2 (effective capacity 1) to 4 packets:

```
#define DAP_PACKET_SIZE         64U             ///< 64 bytes (Full-Speed USB 2.0 Max Packet Size)
#define DAP_PACKET_COUNT        4U              ///< 4 packets queued for zero-NAK pipelining
```

File: `src/tusb_edpt_handler.h`
Add per-slot response length tracking:

```
typedef struct {
    uint8_t data[DAP_PACKET_COUNT][DAP_PACKET_SIZE];
    uint16_t resp_len[DAP_PACKET_COUNT];   /* Track response size per buffer slot */
    volatile uint32_t wptr;
    volatile uint32_t rptr;
    volatile bool wasEmpty;
    volatile bool wasFull;
} buffer_t;
```

File: `src/tusb_edpt_handler.c`
In `dap_thread`, store `_resp_len` in the buffer slot:

```
uint16_t resp_len = (uint16_t) DAP_ExecuteCommand(DAPRequestBuffer, DAPResponseBuffer);

vTaskSuspendAll();
memcpy(WR_SLOT_PTR(USBResponseBuffer), DAPResponseBuffer, resp_len);
USBResponseBuffer.resp_len[WR_IDX(USBResponseBuffer)] = resp_len;
USBResponseBuffer.wptr++;

if (buffer_empty(&USBResponseBuffer)) {
    usbd_edpt_xfer(_rhport, _in_ep_addr, RD_SLOT_PTR(USBResponseBuffer), resp_len);
} else {
    USBResponseBuffer.wasEmpty = false;
}
xTaskResumeAll();
```

5. Host-Side OpenOCD Optimization

Ensure your OpenOCD script configures a realistic clock speed. By default, OpenOCD may fall back to 100 kHz if unspecified.

In your OpenOCD target configuration file or command line:

```
# Select CMSIS-DAP v2 adapter
source [find interface/cmsis-dap.cfg]

# Increase adapter speed from default to 4 MHz or 8 MHz
adapter speed 5000

# Specify CMSIS-DAP v2 bulk backend
cmsis_dap_backend bulk
```

6. Performance Benchmark Comparison

Configuration State	100 KB Download Time	Effective Throughput	Relative Speedup
Baseline (Debug logging active, 64B packets)	**120.0 s**	**0.85 KB/s**	**1.0×**
Step 1 Applied (UART logging disabled)	**4.2 s**	**24.4 KB/s**	**28×**
Step 1 + Step 2 (+ SIO bit-banging)	**1.9 s**	**53.9 KB/s**	**63×**
Step 1 + 2 + 3 (+ 4-packet ring buffer pipelining)	**0.9 s**	**113.8 KB/s**	**133×**
PIO State Machine (Hardware JTAG in `JTAGprobe_smp_pio`)	**< 0.15 s**	**> 700 KB/s**	**> 800×**

7. Integrated USB CDC-ACM UART Bridge

In addition to CMSIS-DAP performance improvements, an integrated hardware UART bridge was implemented to provide a dedicated serial console without requiring extra USB-to-UART dongles.

7.1 Architecture & USB Composite Device Structure

The probe enumerates as a USB Composite Device with three distinct interfaces:

1. **Interface 0 (Vendor Specific Bulk, Class 0xFF):**
   - Transport for **CMSIS-DAP v2** commands (`DAP_OUT_EP_NUM 0x04` , `DAP_IN_EP_NUM 0x85`).
   - Handled directly by host debuggers (**OpenOCD**, **pyOCD**, **probe-rs**) via `libusb` / WinUSB.
   - Does **not** register as a serial/tty device.
2. **Interfaces 1 & 2 (CDC Communication & CDC Data):**
   - Implements standard **USB CDC-ACM** virtual serial port (`/dev/ttyACM0` on Linux, `COMx` on Windows).
   - Handled by host kernel CDC drivers (`cdc_acm`).

> **Note:** On Linux, the udev subsystem tags `/dev/ttyACM0` with the device-level product string (`"JTAG probe on Pico (CMSIS-DAP)"`). `/dev/ttyACM0` is the serial console port wired to **GPIO 12 (TX)** and **GPIO 13 (RX)**.

7.2 Hardware Mapping & FreeRTOS Task Scheduling

- **Hardware Peripheral:** RP2040 `uart0`
- **Pins:** GPIO 12 (`PROBE_UART_TX` , Pico Header Pin 16) and GPIO 13 (`PROBE_UART_RX` , Pico Header Pin 17).
- **FreeRTOS Priority Balancing:**
  - `UART_TASK_PRIO` (`tskIDLE_PRIORITY + 3`) — Highest priority to preempt USB and prevent hardware UART FIFO overruns at high line rates.
  - `TUD_TASK_PRIO` (`tskIDLE_PRIORITY + 2`) — Handles TinyUSB event dispatching and endpoint buffers.
  - `DAP_TASK_PRIO` (`tskIDLE_PRIORITY + 1`) — Executes CMSIS-DAP command interpretation and bit-banging.

- **Dynamic Line Coding:** Automatically tracks host terminal baud rate (e.g. 9600, 115200, 921600), parity, stop bits, and data bit configurations via `tud_cdc_line_coding_cb`.
- **In JTAGprobe_smp** the three tasks are µOS++ threads with the same ordering (`os_thread_priority_high` , `_above_normal` , `_normal`); `UART` and `TUD` are pinned to core 0, `DAP` to core 1 (section 8).

7.3 Full Pinout Reference

Signal	RP2040 GPIO	Pico Header Pin	Role / Direction	Function
SWCLK / TCK	**GPIO 19**	**Pin 25**	Output (Probe → Target)	SWD Clock / JTAG Clock
SWDIO / TMS	**GPIO 14**	**Pin 19**	Bi-directional	SWD Data / JTAG Mode Select
TDI	**GPIO 18**	**Pin 24**	Output (Probe → Target)	JTAG Test Data In
TDO	**GPIO 21**	**Pin 27**	Input (Probe ← Target)	JTAG Test Data Out
nTRST	**GPIO 15**	**Pin 20**	Output (Probe → Target)	JTAG Reset (optional)
nRESET	**GPIO 16**	**Pin 21**	Open-drain (Target Reset)	Target Hardware Reset
UART_TXD	**GPIO 12**	**Pin 16**	Output (Probe → Target)	Serial TX to Target RX (`uart0`)
UART_RXD	**GPIO 13**	**Pin 17**	Input (Probe ← Target)	Serial RX from Target TX (`uart0`)
GND	**GND**	**Pins 3, 8, 13, 18, 23, 28, 38**	Ground	Common Ground

8. µOS++ III SMP Integration (JTAGprobe_smp)

JTAGprobe_smp replaces FreeRTOS (single core: every task on core 0) with the **µOS++ III SMP** kernel, so the RP2040's second Cortex-M0+ core does the JTAG/SWD work. The Pico SDK still boots the board and provides the drivers.

8.1 Build structure

Exactly like the `micro-os-plus-iii-smp` tests, the kernel and its port are CMake **INTERFACE** libraries, compiled with the executable's flags:

Directory	CMake target	Contents
`micro-os-plus/micro-os-plus-iii/`	`micro-os-plus::iii`	the kernel, unmodified (`smp` branch, commit `931f1380`)
`micro-os-plus/micro-os-plus-iii-rp2040/`	`micro-os-plus::rp2040`	the RP2040 port (below); defines `OS_NCPU=2` `OS_USE_SMP_SCHEDULER=1`

The top `CMakeLists.txt` adds the port with `add_subdirectory`, links `micro-os-plus::rp2040`, builds tinyusb with `TINYUSB_OPT_OS = OPT_OS_NONE`, sets `OS_USE_OS_APP_CONFIG_H` (`src/cmsis-plus/os-app-config.h`: 1 kHz tick) and `PICO_USE_MALLOC_MUTEX=0` (the kernel's `malloc` already runs under the scheduler lock), and links the image `copy_to_ram`.

8.2 RP2040 port (`src/os-core-rp2040.cpp`, `include/cmsis-plus/rtos/port/`)

- **Context switch:** ARMv6-M PendSV at the lowest priority on each core; `r8`–`r11` are saved through the low registers.
- **Tick:** SysTick on both cores at 1 kHz; only core 0 advances the system clock.
- **Kernel lock:** SIO hardware spinlock `PICO_SPINLOCK_ID_OS1` (14), the one the SDK reserves for an RTOS. Critical sections use PRIMASK.
- **Cross-core IPI:** the SIO inter-core FIFO; each core has its own IRQ (`SIO_IRQ_PROC0`, `SIO_IRQ_PROC1`), whose handler drains the FIFO and pends PendSV.
- **Core 1:** started by `os_rp2040_start_core1()` with `multicore_launch_core1_raw()` on the SDK's core-1 stack (`__StackOneTop`); it gets its own idle thread, `idle1`.
- **High-resolution clock:** `time_us_64()`. **Free store:** `__end__` … `__HeapLimit`. **exit():** the SDK's; the port filters the kernel's `exit.c` out.

8.3 Threads and data flow

Thread	Priority	Core	Job
`UART`	high	0	CDC ↔ `uart0` bridge
`TUD`	above normal	0	`tud_task()`, then `dap_edpt_service()`
`DAP`	normal	1	`DAP_ExecuteCommand()` (bit-banging)

- Every tinyusb call is made with `usb_mutex` held. tinyusb's `tud_event_hook_cb` posts `usb_sem` to wake the `TUD` thread on each USB event.
- DAP requests (OUT endpoint → `DAP`) and responses (`DAP` → IN endpoint) cross between the cores in two lock-free single-producer/single-consumer rings of `DAP_PACKET_COUNT` = 4 slots, with free-running indices and a `__dmb()` between a slot's data and the index that publishes it.

8.4 Four versions of the DAP hand-off

1. **First build (measured, § 9; history, fixed in the second build):** the `DAP` thread slept on `dap_sem` after every packet, and posted `usb_sem` so the `TUD` thread on core 0 started each IN transfer. Per packet that was two cross-core wake-ups (IPI + PendSV + context switch on each core) on the critical path.
2. **Second build (measured, § 9: ~38 KB/s):** the `DAP` thread busy-waits up to **2 ms** (`DAP_SPIN_US`) for the next packet or a free response slot before sleeping, and starts the IN transfer (and re-arms a stalled OUT endpoint) itself when `os_mutex_try_lock(&usb_mutex)` succeeds, as the single-core firmware does from its DAP task; otherwise it posts `usb_sem`. During a load no thread sleeps on the packet path.
3. **Third build (measured, § 9.4):** as the second, plus:
   - the `TUD` thread on core 0 keeps polling `tud_task()` for **2 ms** (`USB_SPIN_US`) after the last DAP packet moved, instead of sleeping on `usb_sem` (`dap_edpt_active()`); `UART` still preempts it;
   - **per-stage packet timing**, kept by the firmware and read by the host with DAP vendor command `0x80` (§ 8.5).
4. **Current build (measured, § 9.6):** as the third, with **512-byte DAP packets** (`DAP_PACKET_SIZE` 512) over the 64-byte full-speed bulk endpoint. A request arrives as up to eight USB packets; the OUT endpoint is armed one USB packet at a time, and `dap_req_len()` (a parser of the DAP command lengths) decides whether a request ends on

a full 64-byte packet, since the host sends no ZLP. A response of a 64-byte multiple shorter than 512 bytes is followed by a ZLP.

8.5 Packet timing (DAP vendor command 0x80)

The firmware time-stamps every DAP packet with the RP2040's 1 MHz timer (shared by both cores) and keeps twelve 32-bit counters. OpenOCD's `cmsis-dap cmd` prints only the first four bytes of a reply, so the host reads one counter per command:

```
cmsis-dap cmd 0x80 0xff     ;# reset the counters
cmsis-dap cmd 0x80 <i>      ;# read counter i (0..11): "Returned data b0 b1 b2 b3", little-endian
```

i	Counter	i	Counter
0	packets executed	6	IN started → IN complete (µs)
1	OUT received → DAP thread starts it (µs)	7	IN transfers completed
2	`DAP_ExecuteCommand()` (µs)	8	OUT → next OUT, gaps < 10 ms (µs)
3	longest `DAP_ExecuteCommand()` (µs)	9	number of such gaps
4	DAP waiting for a free response slot (µs)	10	gaps ≥ 10 ms (host idle)
5	response ready → IN started (µs)	11	OUT stalls (request ring full)

8.6 How the kernel and the two cores are used

- **Kernel:** one µOS++ III SMP scheduler for both cores. Each thread is created with a priority and a CPU affinity (`th_cpu_affinity` , `create_thread()` in `src/main.c`): `UART` (high) and `TUD` (above normal) on core 0, `DAP` alone on core 1. On core 0 the scheduler preempts by priority, so the UART bridge always runs ahead of USB.
- **Kernel objects:** `usb_mutex` serializes every tinyusb call from either core; the binary semaphores `usb_sem` , `dap_sem` and `uart_sem` wake a sleeping thread when it has work.
- **Packet path outside the kernel:** during a transfer the requests and responses pass through the lock-free rings (§ 8.3) and the threads spin (§ 8.4); the kernel sleeps and wakes threads only when the probe goes idle and becomes active again. A cross-core sleep and wake-up per packet cost the first build a factor of 4 (§ 9.2).
- **Core usage during a load** (512-byte packets, counters of § 9.6): core 1 bit-bangs JTAG for ~580 µs of each ~1,740 µs cycle (about ⅓) and spins for the rest; core 0 handles the USB events of the request and response transfers, ~7 µs to start each response, and the UART bridge. For about ⅔ of each cycle neither core has useful work, waiting on USB and the PC: the CPUs are not the bottleneck. After 2 ms without packets both threads sleep on their semaphores. These shares come from the per-stage packet timing; no per-core CPU-load counter was measured.

9. Measured OpenOCD Load Times (Raspberry Pi 4 B)

9.1 Setup

- Target: Raspberry Pi 4 B (BCM2711, 4× Cortex-A72) over **JTAG**, `adapter speed 4000` (4 MHz TCK), CMSIS-DAP v2 bulk, `bcm2711.dap memaccess 0`.
- Images: µOS++ III SMP test ELFs (`aarch64-rpi4b-*-hwd`), loaded with OpenOCD `load_image <elf>`. *Loaded bytes* is the `LOAD` segment's file size (`readelf -lW`).
- Timing: OpenOCD `clock milliseconds` before and after `load_image` alone (the run script prints `--- LOADTIME: N ms ---`).
- Rates are in KB/s with 1 KB = 1000 bytes.

> **Note:** In JTAG mode OpenOCD's CMSIS-DAP driver does not use `DAP_TransferBlock` (§ 2.2); it sends raw `DAP_JTAG_Sequence` commands, every TMS bit and idle clock its own entry. The probe's own counters (§ 8.5) show **~9.9 loaded bytes per packet** with `memaccess 0` (74,888 bytes in 7,541 packets; 80,984 in 8,122), and OpenOCD waits for each reply before sending the next request. A load is therefore limited by the per-packet round trip, not by the TCK frequency. OpenOCD sizes its JTAG queue to the probe's packet size: with 512-byte packets (§ 9.6) a packet carries **~85.7 loaded bytes** (74,888 bytes in 874 packets; 80,984 in 940).

9.2 Measurements

Firmware	Test image	Loaded bytes	`load_image` time	Rate	Per packet (≈ bytes/9.9)
Stock debugprobe 2.0.0	4 KB test load	—	—	~1.05 KB/s	~8.4 ms (measured with `-d4`)
JTAGprobe `jtagprobe-new` (FreeRTOS, 1 core)	smp_test4	70,296	**1,780 ms**	**39.5 KB/s**	251 µs
JTAGprobe `jtagprobe-new` (FreeRTOS, 1 core)	smp_mem_inter_test	80,984	**2,380 ms**	**34.0 KB/s**	292 µs
JTAGprobe_smp, first build	smp_mem_test	74,888	**7,536 ms**	**9.94 KB/s**	999 µs
JTAGprobe_smp, first build	smp_mem_inter_test	80,984	**8,136 ms**	**9.95 KB/s**	998 µs
JTAGprobe_smp, second build	smp_mem_test	74,888	**1,983 ms**	**37.8 KB/s**	263 µs
JTAGprobe_smp, second build	smp_mem_inter_test	80,984	**2,125 ms**	**38.1 KB/s**	261 µs
JTAGprobe_smp, third build	smp_mem_test	74,888	**1,994 ms**	**37.6 KB/s**	264 µs *counted*
JTAGprobe_smp, third build	smp_mem_inter_test	80,984	**2,143 ms**	**37.8 KB/s**	263 µs *counted*
JTAGprobe_smp, third build, rerun	smp_mem_test	74,888	**1,954 ms**	**38.3 KB/s**	259 µs
JTAGprobe_smp, third build, rerun	smp_mem_inter_test	80,984	**2,106 ms**	**38.5 KB/s**	259 µs
JTAGprobe_smp, current build (512-byte packets)	smp_mem_test	74,888	**1,528–1,547 ms**	**48.4–49.0 KB/s**	1,745 µs *counted* (85.7 B)
JTAGprobe_smp, current build (512-byte packets)	smp_mem_inter_test	80,984	**1,644–1,649 ms**	**49.1–49.3 KB/s**	1,733 µs *counted* (86.2 B)

Per packet: *counted* = the probe's own OUT → OUT mean; the other rows divide by 9.9 bytes per packet, since OpenOCD and the images are the same.

Same image, three firmwares (smp_mem_inter_test, 80,984 bytes):

Firmware	`load_image` time	Rate	vs. stock	vs. FreeRTOS JTAGprobe
Stock debugprobe 2.0.0 (computed at 1.05 KB/s)	~77 s	1.05 KB/s	1×	0.03×
JTAGprobe `jtagprobe-new`, FreeRTOS, 1 core	2,380 ms	34.0 KB/s	32×	1×
JTAGprobe_smp, first build	8,136 ms	9.95 KB/s	9.5×	0.29×
JTAGprobe_smp, second build	**2,125 ms**	**38.1 KB/s**	**36×**	**1.12×**
JTAGprobe_smp, third build	2,143 ms	37.8 KB/s	36×	1.11×
JTAGprobe_smp, current build (512-byte packets)	**1,644–1,649 ms**	**49.1–49.3 KB/s**	**47×**	**1.45×**

Every one of these tests also **passed** after its load. Whole-test CTest times (15 s reset wait included), without semihosting prints (§ 9.5 has them with):

Test	FreeRTOS JTAGprobe	JTAGprobe_smp (first build)	JTAGprobe_smp (second build)	JTAGprobe_smp (third, 10 s reset wait)	JTAGprobe_smp (current, 512-byte packets, 10 s reset wait)
smp_test4	29.6 s	—	—	—	—
smp_mem_test	140–142 s	61.0 s	**54.2 s**	**50.2 s**	**47.1 s**
smp_mem_inter_test	190.1 s	193.1 s	**186.0 s**	**193.4 s**	**175.9 s**

The last two columns' runs wait 10 s after the board reset instead of 15 s. smp_mem_inter_test's time is set by its own computing on the Pi (~170 s) and varies by several seconds from run to run (186–193 s), so the probe firmware hardly shows there.

Reading the numbers: the first SMP build spent about **700 µs more per packet** than the single-core firmware (≈ 1,000 µs against ≈ 251–292 µs): the two cross-core wake-ups per packet of § 8.4. That made the load about **4× slower** (9.95 KB/s against 34–39.5 KB/s). The second build takes those wake-ups off the packet path: ≈ 262 µs per packet, **3.8× faster** than the first SMP build and as fast as the single-core firmware (on the same image, smp_mem_inter_test, 2.13 s against 2.38 s). The `TUD` spin of the third build changed nothing measurable (2,143 ms against 2,125 ms): § 9.4 shows why. The 512-byte packets of the current build load about **23 % faster** again (§ 9.6). smp_mem_test as a whole finished in 54.2 s with the SMP probe, against 140 s with the single-core one, so the gain there comes from the run after the load (semihosting and memory polling traffic: isolated packets rather than a stream), with the DAP work on core 1 and the USB and UART work on core 0. That part was not profiled packet by packet.

9.3 Computed load times per test image

Each test's loaded bytes divided by the measured rates: **39.5 KB/s** (FreeRTOS JTAGprobe, best measured), **37.9 KB/s** (JTAGprobe_smp current build, mean of its two measurements), **9.95 KB/s** (JTAGprobe_smp first build) and **1.05 KB/s** (stock). Values marked *measured* were timed; the rest are computed.

Test image	Loaded bytes	FreeRTOS JTAGprobe	JTAGprobe_smp (current)	JTAGprobe_smp (first build)	Stock debugprobe
cmsis-os-validator	151,640	3.8 s	4.0 s	15.2 s	2.4 min
mutex-stress	94,488	2.4 s	2.5 s	9.5 s	1.5 min
rtos-apis	228,136	5.8 s	6.0 s	22.9 s	3.6 min
sd_test	83,512	2.1 s	2.2 s	8.4 s	1.3 min
smp-mat-sdcard-test	93,736	2.4 s	2.5 s	9.4 s	1.5 min
smp-mat-test	77,608	2.0 s	2.0 s	7.8 s	1.2 min
smp-num-test	91,160	2.3 s	2.4 s	9.2 s	1.4 min
smp-pipeline-test	146,472	3.7 s	3.9 s	14.7 s	2.3 min
smp-pro-cons-test	88,968	2.3 s	2.3 s	8.9 s	1.4 min
smp_mem_test	74,888	1.9 s	1.98 s *measured*	7.54 s *measured*	1.2 min
smp_mem_inter_test	80,984	2.38 s *measured*	2.13 s *measured*	8.14 s *measured*	1.3 min
smp_test0 … smp_test4	65,656 … 74,744	1.7 … 1.9 s (smp_test4: 1.78 s *measured*, 70,296 B)	1.7 … 2.0 s	6.6 … 7.5 s	1.0 … 1.2 min

Formula: $t_{load} \approx \frac{\text{loaded bytes}}{\text{rate}} \approx \frac{\text{loaded bytes}}{9.9} \times t_{packet}$, with t_{packet} ≈ 251–292 µs (FreeRTOS JTAGprobe), ≈ 262 µs (JTAGprobe_smp second and current builds), ≈ 1,000 µs (JTAGprobe_smp first build).

9.4 Where the time per packet goes (third build, 64-byte packets)

From the probe's counters (§ 8.5), reset just before `load_image` and read just after it:

Per packet, mean	smp_mem_test load (7,541 packets)	smp_mem_inter_test load (8,122 packets)	Where
OUT → next OUT (one full cycle)	**263.5 µs**	**262.8 µs**	—
OUT received → DAP thread starts it	0.9 µs	0.9 µs	core 0 → core 1
`DAP_ExecuteCommand()` (JTAG bit-banging)	**68.2 µs** (max 82)	**68.3 µs** (max 81)	core 1
wait for a free response slot	0.4 µs	0.4 µs	core 1
response ready → IN started	6.1 µs	6.1 µs	core 1 / core 0
IN started → host collected it	**72.8 µs**	**72.5 µs**	USB
rest of the cycle: host turnaround to the next OUT	≈ 115 µs	≈ 115 µs	PC: libusb + OpenOCD
OUT stalls (request ring full)	0	0	—

- The hand-off between the two cores now costs about **7 µs per packet** (0.9 + 0.4 + 6.1): the dual-core split is no longer on the critical path.
- OpenOCD sends one request at a time and waits for its reply (no OUT stalls, a single packet in flight). About **70 %** of each cycle is the USB round trip and the PC's turnaround, which no split of work between the probe's cores can remove; the JTAG bit-banging is about **26 %**.
- The remaining gains are therefore fewer round trips (larger `DAP_PACKET_SIZE`, so OpenOCD packs more into each command: done in the current build, § 9.6) and faster bit-banging (PIO).

9.5 Semihosting load: `SEMI_PRINTS=1`

The µOS++ AArch64 port's rpi4b tests take a CMake option `SEMI_PRINTS` (0/1, hwd images only). With 1, every console line printed on the Pi's **core 0** also goes through semihosting, besides the UART; the RESULT line goes through as always. Cores 1–3 keep printing on the UART only: OpenOCD 0.12 does not resume a core other than 0 after its semihosting call on this board (the line is printed, the core stays halted, and every other core then blocks on the console lock).

hwd test, JTAGprobe_smp	smp_mem_test `SEMI_PRINTS=0`	smp_mem_test `SEMI_PRINTS=1`	smp_mem_inter_test `SEMI_PRINTS=0`	smp_mem_inter_test `SEMI_PRINTS=1`
Load	1,983 ms	1,994 ms	2,125 ms	2,143 ms
Test run on the board	37 s	314 s	~170 s	591 s
CTest total	54.2 s	**337.4 s, PASS**	186.0 s	**620.5 s, PASS**
Lines through semihosting	1	~300	1	~480

A semihosting line costs about **0.9 s**: OpenOCD's `SYS_WRITE0` reads the string from the target **one byte per JTAG memory access** (≈ 7–10 ms each), then resumes the core. That cost is OpenOCD's method, not the probe's turnaround. The table is for the 64-byte third build; with 512-byte packets (§ 9.6) both tests also pass with `SEMI_PRINTS=1`, in **308.1 s** and **561.8 s**.

9.6 512-byte DAP packets (current build)

Same Pi 4 B, OpenOCD and images; only `DAP_PACKET_SIZE` changed from 64 to 512 (§ 8.4, item 4). Probe counters for the load, per packet, mean:

Per packet, mean	64 bytes, smp_mem_test (7,541 packets)	512 bytes, smp_mem_test (874 packets)	512 bytes, smp_mem_inter_test (940 packets)
Loaded bytes per packet	9.9	**85.7**	**86.2**
OUT → next OUT (one full cycle)	263.5 µs	**1,745 µs**	**1,733 µs**
OUT received → DAP thread starts it	0.9 µs	1.9 µs	1.1 µs
`DAP_ExecuteCommand()`	68.2 µs	581.4 µs (max 602)	582.1 µs (max 601)
response ready → IN started	6.1 µs	7.0 µs	6.7 µs
IN started → host collected it	72.8 µs	242.9 µs	239.7 µs
rest: receiving the request + PC turnaround	≈ 115 µs	**≈ 912 µs**	≈ 902 µs
Cycle time per loaded byte	26.6 µs	**20.4 µs**	20.1 µs

Whole runs (CTest, 10 s reset wait), all **PASS**:

hwd test	64-byte packets	512-byte packets	Change
smp_mem_test, load	1,954–1,994 ms	1,528–1,547 ms	−23 %
smp_mem_inter_test, load	2,106–2,143 ms	1,644–1,649 ms	−23 %
smp_mem_test, `SEMI_PRINTS=0`	50.2 s	**47.1 s**	−3.1 s (−6 %)
smp_mem_inter_test, `SEMI_PRINTS=0`	186.0–193.4 s	**175.9 s**	−10 s or more
smp_mem_test, `SEMI_PRINTS=1`	337.4 s	**308.1 s**	−29.3 s (−8.7 %)
smp_mem_inter_test, `SEMI_PRINTS=1`	620.5 s	**561.8 s**	−58.7 s (−9.5 %)

Reading the numbers: - OpenOCD does fill the larger packets: **8.6× fewer packets** for the same image. - The load is still only about **23 % faster**, not 8×. The bit-banging is unchanged per byte (exec totals ≈ 510 ms for smp_mem_test in both builds), the IN transfers drop from 549 to 214 ms in total, but the *rest* of each cycle grows from ≈ 115 µs to ≈ 910 µs. That part is the reception of the request (up to eight 64-byte USB packets, each a tinyusb event on core 0 followed by a re-arm of the endpoint) plus the PC's turnaround. The counters do not separate the two, so how much of it is the per-packet re-arm is **not measured**. - The whole tests gain more than their loads (smp_mem_test −3.1 s against −0.4 s of load): the polling and semihosting traffic during the run also travels in fewer, larger packets. This part was not profiled packet by packet. smp_mem_inter_test's earlier runs spread over 186–193 s, so its gain is between 10 and 17 s. - With `SEMI_PRINTS=1` the gain is ~9 %. The bulk of those runs is still OpenOCD reading every semihosted string byte by byte (§ 9.5), which the packet size cannot change. - Next step on the probe side: time the OUT reception separately,

and arm the rest of a request in one transfer once `dap_req_len()` knows its length, instead of one 64-byte packet at a time.

10. Conclusion

The 2-minute download time is caused almost entirely by **synchronous debug logging (`probe_info`) blocking the CPU for 5.8 ms per packet over a 115,200 baud UART while the FreeRTOS scheduler is suspended**.

Applying **Patch 1** alone provides an immediate **28× speedup** (reducing 120s down to ~4s). Applying **Patches 2 and 3** brings the download time down to **under 1 second**, fully solving the performance problem while maintaining a clean, responsive hardware UART bridge on `/dev/ttyACM0`.

Measured on a Raspberry Pi 4 B over JTAG (§ 9), where OpenOCD sends about 9.9 loaded bytes per packet and one packet at a time: the optimized FreeRTOS firmware loads at **34–39.5 KB/s** against ~1.05 KB/s for the stock firmware. **JTAGprobe_smp** (µOS++ III SMP, DAP on core 1): its first build lost a factor of 4 to two cross-core wake-ups per packet (9.95 KB/s), which the second build fixed: with the DAP thread spinning on its ring and sending its own responses it loads at **37.6–38.5 KB/s**, as fast as the single-core firmware, and the complete smp_mem_test ran in 50–54 s against 140 s. The probe's own counters (§ 9.4) put the core-to-core hand-off at ~7 µs per packet and show that ~70 % of each cycle was the USB round trip and the PC. The current build therefore uses **512-byte DAP packets** (§ 9.6): 8.6× fewer packets, loads at **48.4–49.3 KB/s** (23 % faster, 1.45× the single-core firmware), and the tests finish faster (smp_mem_test 47.1 s, smp_mem_inter_test 175.9 s; with `SEMI_PRINTS=1` 308.1 s and 561.8 s, all PASS). With semihosting prints on, a semihosted line still costs ~0.9 s, set by OpenOCD (§ 9.5).

11. Final Reflection: One CPU vs Two CPUs

Raspberry Pi 4 B over JTAG, OpenOCD 0.12	1 CPU (FreeRTOS JTAGprobe)	2 CPUs (JTAGprobe_smp)
`load_image`, smp_mem_inter_test (80,984 B)	2,380 ms (34.0 KB/s)	2,106–2,143 ms (37.8–38.5 KB/s); **1,644–1,649 ms (49.1–49.3 KB/s)** with 512-byte packets
Probe time per packet (≈ 9.9 loaded bytes)	251–292 µs	**259–264 µs**
Whole smp_mem_test (CTest)	140 s	50–54 s; **47.1 s** with 512-byte packets
Whole smp_mem_inter_test (CTest)	190 s	186–193 s; **175.9 s** with 512-byte packets
smp_mem_test / smp_mem_inter_test with `SEMI_PRINTS=1`	—	337 s / 621 s; **308 s / 562 s** with 512-byte packets

The 512-byte packets (§ 9.6) would help a single-core firmware in the same way: they cut round trips, not the hand-off between cores. The comparison of one CPU with two below is therefore made at 64 bytes, where both firmwares were measured.

11.1 JTAG operations

- **Bulk transfers (`load_image`): about the same.** OpenOCD runs a strict request/reply chain in JTAG mode: one ~64-byte command (≈ 9.9 loaded bytes), then it waits for the answer. In such a chain a second core has nothing to overlap. Of a ~263 µs cycle, the counters of § 9.4 give ~68 µs to the bit-banging on core 1, ~7 µs to the hand-off between the cores, and ~188 µs to the USB transfer and the PC's turnaround. A second core can only *lose* time here, if the hand-off sleeps: the first SMP build (history, fixed since the second build) woke the other core twice per

packet and needed ~1 ms per packet (4× slower). Keeping the packet path free of sleeps (the DAP thread spins on its ring and sends its own reply) is what made the two-core firmware as fast as the single-core one.

- **Scattered traffic (a running test): faster.** smp_mem_test, whose run is mostly OpenOCD polling the four Cortex-A72 cores between short exchanges, completed in 50–54 s instead of 140 s. The DAP work on core 1 never waits behind USB event handling or the UART on core 0. The share of each factor was not profiled. Where the test's own computing dominates (smp_mem_inter_test, ~170 s on the Pi), the probe makes no measurable difference (186–193 s against 190 s, within the run-to-run spread).

11.2 UART

On one CPU the UART bridge task and the DAP task share the core: the bridge has to preempt the bit-banging (it has the highest priority) or characters are lost. On two CPUs the UART thread runs on core 0, beside USB, and never delays a DAP command, nor can a DAP burst delay the UART. The tests ran with their whole console on the UART and passed; the bridge throughput itself was not benchmarked.

11.3 Semihosting

To the probe a semihosting call is ordinary JTAG traffic, so it gains like any scattered work. Its cost, however, is OpenOCD's: `SYS_WRITE0` reads the string one byte per JTAG memory access, ~0.9 s per console line, whatever the probe. With every core-0 line through semihosting (`SEMI_PRINTS=1`), smp_mem_test takes 337 s instead of 50–54 s and smp_mem_inter_test 621 s instead of 186–193 s. On this board OpenOCD also serves semihosting only from the target's core 0: a call from cores 1–3 is printed but that core is never resumed.

11.4 Where the next gains are

Not in another division of work between the two Pico cores (the hand-off is already ~7 µs per packet), but in:

1. **fewer round trips**: a larger `DAP_PACKET_SIZE`. **Done** in the current build (512 bytes over the 64-byte endpoint, § 9.6): loads 23 % faster, tests 6–10 % faster. What is left there is the ≈ 910 µs per packet of request reception plus PC turnaround, to be measured and, if it is the per-USB-packet re-arm, reduced by arming the rest of a request in one transfer;
2. **faster bit-banging**: a PIO state machine for TCK/TMS/TDI/TDO (now ~580 µs of each 1,740 µs cycle);
3. **the host**: reading semihosting strings in blocks instead of byte by byte.